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FEATURED

City covers all Flock cameras amid program suspension

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A Flock camera in downtown Dayton is among automatic license plate readers covered in Dayton following the suspension of the city's fixed-site program. SYDNEY DAWES / STAFF

Dayton workers have placed bags over the city's Flock cameras.

This follows the city's suspension of use of its Flock cameras — a type of automatic license plate reader that generates data that can be accessed by departments all over the country — after realizing its data was being scanned for immigration reasons, in violation of city policy. A Dayton Daily News investigation found other area police departments allow their data to be accessed for immigration purposes.

A few cameras in the Third Street and Courthouse Plaza area — one in front of Dayton City Hall — were covered in black plastic bags Monday evening. A city spokesperson confirmed Wednesday that all cameras have been covered.

The city's program includes 72 fixed-site ALPR cameras. They capture the make, model and color of passing vehicles, as well as other visual details, like damage or alterations, such as broken taillights and aftermarket rims or wheels. They send real-time alerts when license plate numbers match a reported stolen vehicle or a car being sought by law enforcement. This technology is mounted to a pole or traffic signal and is often powered by solar panels.

Privacy advocacy groups say ALPRs are a powerful mass surveillance tool that has a grave potential for misuse, since the information they collect can be accessed with little to no accountability. Police officials claim they provide valuable evidence in criminal investigations that could otherwise go unsolved.

Dozens of community members have addressed Dayton's city commission at its meetings this past month, with speakers sharing outrage over the May announcement that a policy violation in the city's Flock camera system resulted in more than 7,000 searches related to immigration enforcement made by outside agencies.

Representatives of the city manager's office have said the suspension of the Flock camera program means the cameras have not been active. The Dayton Police Department worked with the city to cover the cameras — an act to mitigate concerns from the community.

City leaders during their May 20 commission meeting discussed covering the cameras as the city weighs what will happen to the cameras during the program's suspension. Dayton city commissioners have called for the removal of the cameras.

“I join my colleagues in requesting the Flock cameras be taken down. I think we’re working through how soon we can do that,” Commissioner Darius Beckham said during the commission’s Wednesday, May 20, meeting.

The city has also shared an information guide about ALPRs. There, city officials have stated their next steps. This includes hiring an independent company to conduct a full audit, hosting engagement sessions and collecting survey data.

“Once the audit is complete, the City will publish findings and recommendations,” according to the city’s ALPR FAQ. “The City Commission will make final decision on ALPR camera use.”

Flock is a leading maker of ALPR technology. Not all ALPR systems allow captured data to be stored and shared with other departments to the same extent.

The Dayton Police Department, the Montgomery County Sheriff’s Office and other regional police departments denied Dayton Daily News requests, made under Ohio public records law, that seek to obtain audit information showing how those agencies are sharing Flock ALPR data. Officials say the records are confidential and exempt from public records law. This news outlet is disputing those assertions.

Commission to decide next steps after an independent audit.

Flock cameras: How they work and why some are concerned

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